

“MY PEOPLE, I DIE INNOCENT!”

Louis XVI of France, before his execution



This detail from a fresco depicts the battle of Raclawice on April 4, 1794, when Polish troops led by General Tadeusz Kosciuszko defeated the Russians.

Robespierre (1758–94), was, in effect, in control of the government. Members of the same political club as Robespierre—the **Jacobins**—also became involved in the surveillance of potential suspects.

In **Saint-Domingue (Haiti)**, fighting on the island was complicated by the arrival of **British troops**. Prompted by the French declaration of war in 1792, Britain hoped to seize control of the island and add it to their other Caribbean sugar islands, such as Jamaica. The struggle lasted for five years.

In the US, **Eli Whitney** (1765–1825) perfected a machine called the **cotton gin**, which he patented the following year. Many planters wanted to diversify into the cotton trade, but the long-staple variety of cotton grown—which yields long, silky fibers—could only be cultivated near the coast. Heavily seeded **short-staple** cotton—producing shorter fibers—was the only other option, but removing the seeds was a laborious and time-consuming task. Whitney's machine, however, combed cotton very quickly, and it led to the development of the cotton industry in the American South.

Back in Europe, **Poland** faced a **second partition**, this time with Prussia and Russia taking some 115,000 square miles (300,000 sq km), leaving Poland a fraction of its former size. Poland ceded eastern provinces from Livonia to Moldavia to Russia, while Prussia was given Great Poland, Torun, and the port city of Gdansk.

17,000

THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE EXECUTED DURING “THE TERROR”

Britain and Spain averted a war over the **Nootka Sound** in the Pacific, northwest of the American territory, by signing the Second Nootka Sound Convention. Another agreement was signed the following year in which Spain capitulated to British demands. The diplomatic standoff—which eventually involved the European allies of both sides—had started in 1789 when Spain seized three British ships sailing nearby. This escalated into a battle of words over who had **the right to settle** in that territory.

In China, East India Company officer George Macartney (1737–1806) had arrived in Beijing (Peking) in 1792 with a party of 94 people and a range of British goods. He was finally presented to the emperor Qianlong (1735–99) in September 1793. The British government and the East India Company were eager to expand trade between Britain and China, but Qing officials were not interested and they refused to negotiate a treaty.

THE REIGN OF TERROR in France eliminated the enemies of the Committee of Public Safety on the left and right by 1794. However, the committee felt the need to go further and suspended a suspect's right to public trial and legal assistance, with juries instructed to issue either acquittal or death. This measure was passed in June, but little more than a month later a revolt in the National Convention ended the reign of Robespierre. Known as the **Thermidorian Reaction**, it refers to 9 Thermidor Year II (July 27, 1794), the date in the French Revolutionary Calendar. This change to the calendar system began in 1792 and lasted until 1806. The calendar began on the year of the anniversary of the



Maximilien Robespierre
The head of the Committee of Public Safety tried to eliminate his enemies, but he ended up dying on the guillotine.



Revolutionary coin

The French king Louis XVI was replaced on the country's coinage by the figure of Hercules, flanked by Liberty and Equality.

proclamation of the Republic (September 21, also the autumn equinox). Each month was 30 days long, and was divided into “decades” of 10 days.

On July 27, Robespierre was arrested and he and another 100 supporters faced the same **guillotine** used on their enemies.

This was a turning point in the French Revolution, as the National Convention asserted its strength, but the Terror had exacted a high price—some 17,000 people were officially executed and hundreds of thousands arrested.

In Saint-Domingue, the former slave turned military leader, General **Toussaint Louverture**, was persuaded to leave the Spanish and join French Commissioner **Léger-Félicité Sonthonax** (1763–1813) to lead French Republican troops—though he later broke with the French (see 1803). Sonthonax was posted to Saint-Domingue in 1792 to keep the island under control after the slave rebellion, and to enforce the National Convention's ruling that free people of color were to have equality. However, France's declaration of war against Britain had complicated the situation, and Spain and Britain fought alongside the former slaves. This prompted Sonthonax to look to existing slaves as possible troops. In 1793 he promised slaves in the north of the island **freedom** if they fought for the French cause, and by that August he decreed the **abolition of slavery**, ratified by the National Convention on February 4, 1794.

Meanwhile, in **Poland**, anger had mounted over the devastating partition the previous year, and patriots organized the **Polish Rebellion of 1794**. Despite an initial victory in Russian-held Warsaw, the Poles were crushed by Russia's forces.

“I WAS BORN A SLAVE, BUT NATURE GAVE ME A SOUL OF A FREE MAN...”

Toussaint Louverture, former slave and military leader

China rejects British request for more trading ports

September 5
Reign of Terror in France begins led by Maximilien Robespierre (1758–94) (to 1794)

January 11 Third Nootka Convention between Britain and Spain ends dispute over Pacific Northwest

March 24 Polish uprising begins against Russia and Prussia over partitions

July 28 Maximilien Robespierre executed

June 26 First use of aircraft in battle when French use observation balloon in battle of Fleurus against Austrians

Start of Qajar dynasty in Persia

October 16 Marie Antoinette is executed

February 4 France abolishes slavery